



SURE

RMA · FORENSIC DUE DILIGENCE



Anatomy of a Fake Purchase Order

How an “irrevocable” ICPO reveals itself as a time-trap — and an invoice pointed at you.

CASE STUDY · ILLUSTRATIVE



INTRODUCTION

The order that costs you to fulfill

An ICPO — an “Irrevocable Corporate Purchase Order” — is meant to signal a serious buyer. In the refined-fuels broker circuit it often signals the opposite: a scripted procedure designed to extract fees, documents and weeks of your time against a cargo that was never there. The word “irrevocable” does a lot of work; the structure behind it does none.

About this case — this is an illustrative composite of the purchase-order patterns SURE RMA sees repeatedly in the FOB tank-to-tank fuel circuit. Names, figures and parties are representative, not a specific engagement — but every red flag below is drawn from real documents.

CHAPTER 1

The setup

A polished ICPO arrives on letterhead: a large trial volume, a twelve-month recurring quantity, a household refinery grade, and a nine-step “FOB tank-to-tank” procedure that reads like a checklist. It names a bank, an officer, a corporate profile boasting a nine-figure credit facility. Everything is built to make the deal feel real — and to make asking basic questions feel like an insult.

CHAPTER 2

The dossier: seven red flags

- 1 You pay to prove you're real.** The procedure asks you to wire “storage-day” fees to the other side's tank farm to “confirm readiness” — before a barrel or a contract is verified. A genuine FOB deal never charges you to demonstrate you're serious.
- 2 A “procedure” stands in for a contract.** A multi-step TTT/TTO choreography — ICPO, TSA, storage payment, NCNDA/IMFPA, injection, dip test — replaces the only things a real deal needs: an enforceable sale contract and a bank instrument.
- 3 Round trial, fantasy recurring volume.** A neat six-figure “trial” and a larger monthly quantity for a year — chosen to impress, with no discharge schedule, no named refinery and no allocation proof.
- 4 Payment by MT103/TT, no LC or SBLC.** Money moves on trust in one direction, with no banking instrument protecting either side. Once a wire leaves, it's gone.
- 5 Commission both sides, an IMFPA chain behind it.** A fee split “seller-side / buyer-side” plus an NCNDA/IMFPA signals a chain of intermediaries — and, usually, no reachable principal at the end of it.
- 6 Generic product and origin.** “Standard exporter grade,” “non-sanctioned country,” no refinery, no assay, no certificate of origin until deep in the procedure. The specificity a real seller gives is exactly what's missing.



- 7 Prestige you can't verify.** A corporate profile claiming a nine-figure credit facility “on own funds” and name-dropping national oil companies — none of it independently confirmable. The named bank officer resolves to a generic branch inbox, and the company lists more than one registered address.

CHAPTER 3

The verdict

92/100

RISK SCORE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

7

CRITICAL RED FLAGS

~6 min

TIME TO SCORE

An order you have to pay to fulfill isn't an order. It's an invoice pointed at you.

CHAPTER 4

How SURE RMA reads an ICPO

SURE RMA reads the order and everything attached to it in parallel — the ICPO, the storage agreement, the corporate profile, the bank details — and surfaces what a quick read misses: advance-fee structures dressed up as “procedure,” the absence of any bank instrument, commission-chain exposure, and prestige claims that don't survive a second look. Every finding is evidenced, and the output is a single, defensible risk score — in minutes, not weeks.

Check a purchase order before you spend a week on it — free, on a document of your choice.

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